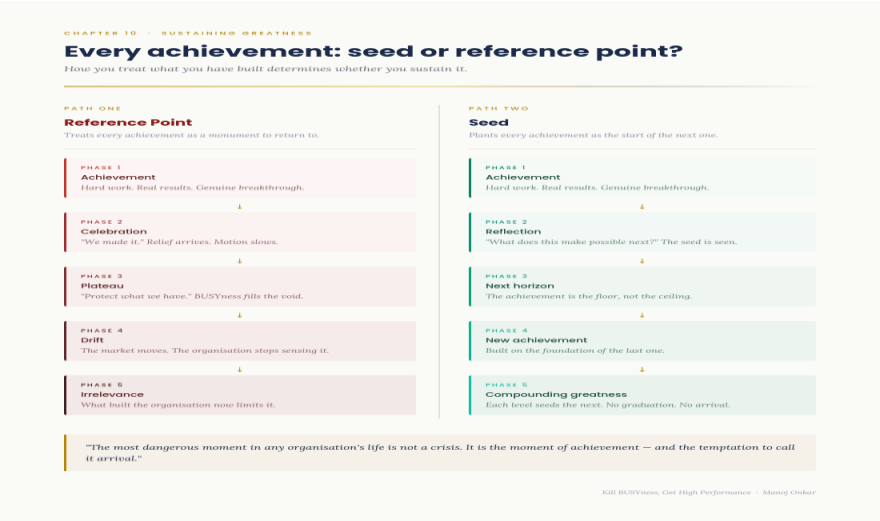


CHAPTER 10

Sustaining Greatness

> *"The most dangerous moment is not a crisis. It is the moment of achievement."*

Excellence is a never-ending game. This is the beginning of the beginning.

Here is the most dangerous moment in any organisation's life.

Not a crisis. Not a failure. Not a period of pressure or difficulty. Those are hard, but they are legible. People know what to do in a crisis — they mobilise, they problem-solve, and they hold together because the threat is visible and the direction is clear.

The most dangerous moment is achievement itself.

The deal is closed. The milestone is hit. The target is exceeded. The transformation feels complete. The organisation exhales — collectively and gratefully — and for a moment, everything feels like arrival.

And that feeling… that beautiful, legitimate, hard-earned feeling of having made it… is the beginning of the end of sustained greatness if you let it be.

Because excellence is not a destination. Excellence is a direction. An infinite direction, extending beyond any achievement, any milestone, any leader's tenure.

Innosight's research on corporate longevity found that the average tenure of a company on the S&P 500 was 33 years in 1964. By 2024, that number had shrunk to approximately 15 to 17 years and is projected to keep falling. Half of all companies currently on the S&P 500 will be replaced by 2030. These are the best-performing companies in the world's largest economy — and their average lifespan on that list has been cut in half within a single working lifetime. The organisations that will remain are not the ones that achieved High-Performance and protected it. They are the ones who treated every achievement as the starting point for the next.

The organisation that understands this does not rest on its accomplishments. It stands on them — using every achievement as the foundation from which the next leap is made.

Every Accomplishment: Reference Point or Seed?

When your organisation hits a significant achievement — a revenue milestone, a product launch, a culture shift, a market breakthrough — it faces a choice that most organisations make without realising they are making it.

It can treat the achievement as a **reference point**. Something to return to. A justification for slowing down. A proof of what was possible that gradually becomes a ceiling rather than a floor. Organisations in this mode talk about past achievements with a kind of reverence that subtly signals the peak has been reached.

Or it can treat the achievement as a **seed**. A foundation for the next leap. Insight gained, capability built, the next horizon now visible more clearly because this horizon has been crossed. The beginning of sustained greatness.

The seed of the next level is always present in the accomplishment of this one. The question is whether the organisation has the eyes to see it, and the discipline to plant rather than rest.

Apple's approach to each of its milestones was never to celebrate arrival. After the Macintosh, Jobs created the iPod. After the iPod, Apple launched the iPhone — which cannibalized the iPod market. After the iPhone, Apple created the App Store, building a new platform economy. When Apple became the first company to hit a $1 trillion market cap in 2018, Tim Cook called it "a moment to pause briefly and celebrate" — and then immediately outlined the next wave of investment. Each achievement was treated as a seed. The market capitalisation today exceeds $3 trillion.

Each Apple milestone was not a destination. It was the seed of the next act of creation. The Macintosh built the design discipline that made the iPod possible. The iPod-iTunes ecosystem proved hardware and software could be fused seamlessly — making the iPhone imaginable. The iPhone created the platform on which the App Store built an new economy. The App Store generated the recurring revenue base that made Services Apple's most profitable division by 2023. None of this was planned in 1997 when the company was 90 days from bankruptcy. All of it was made possible by a leadership orientation that treated every achievement as the starting point for the next one — never as proof that arrival had occurred.

The Indian parallel is the Tata Group across seven generations. Jamshedji Tata created Tata Steel and the city of Jamshedpur in conditions where no industrial infrastructure, no capital markets, and no precedent existed. Each generation that followed did not protect what he built. They used it as the foundation for what came next: Tata Motors, TCS, Tata Power, Taj Hotels. Today TCS alone generates more revenue than the entire group did at the time of India's independence. One hundred and fifty-five years of treating every achievement as a seed, not a monument. That is what sustained greatness looks like across the full arc of time.

The Murugappa Group offers an equally compelling — and perhaps less celebrated — example of the same orientation. Founded in 1900, the group has sustained 28 businesses across five generations of leadership with no governance scandal in 125 years of operation. The founding principle — "Integrity is the bedrock of our business"

— was not a values statement written for an annual report. It was a standard held, generation after generation, in rooms the founder would never enter. When the purpose and standards of an organisation are internalised rather than enforced, they do not require the founder's presence to continue. They require only that each generation of leadership receives them honestly, owns them completely, and passes them forward without dilution. That is what the Murugappa Group has done for over a century. That is what purpose outlasting the leader actually looks like in practice.

General Electric chose differently. Under Jack Welch, GE was ranked the most admired company in the world by Fortune magazine for five consecutive years (1998–2002). The achievements were extraordinary. The problem was what those achievements became under successive leadership — reference points. Proof that the model was right. Reasons not to question what had built the company's success. GE's market capitalisation fell from approximately $600 billion in 2000 to under $90 billion by 2018. In 2021, the company announced — and by 2024 completed — a break into three separate entities. The very success that had defined GE became the structural assumption that limited it.

Key Finding	Source
Average S&P 500 company tenure: 33 years (1964) → ~16 years (2024); half replaced by 2030	*Innosight, "2021 Corporate Longevity Forecast"; 2024 updates*

Key Finding	Source
Apple: Mac → iPod → iPhone → App Store → Services; each milestone used as seed. $3B (1997) → $3T+ (2024)	*Apple investor relations; multiple business history sources*
GE: $600B market cap (2000) → <$90B (2018) after treating past achievements as reference points	*GE corporate history; Forbes analysis*
"It's still Day 1." Every Amazon shareholder letter 1997–2020; HQ named "Day 1"	*Jeff Bezos shareholder letters 1997–2020*
Sustained greatness = Level 5 leadership + building institutions that outlast individual leaders	*Jim Collins, "Good to Great" (2001)*
Tata Group: 155+ years, 7 generations, 30+ companies, 100+ countries	*Tata Group history; R.M. Lala, "The Creation of Wealth"*
INDIA: Murugappa Group — founded 1900, 28 businesses, 5 generations, no governance scandal in 125 years. "Integrity is the bedrock of our business."	*Murugappa Group corporate history; CRISIL ratings; Business Standard analysis*
Long-term oriented companies dramatically outperform short-term optimisers over 20 years	*BCG, long-term value creation research*

Every Breakdown is a Beginning

Ordinary organisations treat breakdowns as problems to be solved. They mobilise to fix them, return to normal once fixed, and carry the residue as a cautionary memory.

High-performance organisations treat breakdowns differently. They metabolise them.

The old response to breakdown: *What went wrong? How do we fix this? How do we get back to where we were?*

The new response: *What does this reveal? What new understanding does this make available? Where does this point us that we have not yet gone?*

The organisation that asks the new questions does not just fix the breakdown — it uses it. It extracts the intelligence embedded in the failure, the structural truth that was hidden by the smooth operation of things that were functioning just well enough to mask what was not.

Toyota's response to its 2010 recall crisis is the most instructive example of this distinction in modern manufacturing. By 2008, Toyota had become the world's largest car manufacturer. A systematic internal review of quality assumptions eventually produced one of the largest recalls in automotive history. Toyota's response was not to defend or minimise. It was to acknowledge precisely what the breakdown revealed — specifically, without self-protection — and to build that revelation into the system. Toyota has been a manufacturing benchmark for over 70 years. Not because it has never broken down. Because it has never treated a breakdown as a failure to be survived rather than an intelligence to be used.

Great organisations do not avoid breakdowns. They metabolise them.

Paradigm-Busting as the Cultural Norm

There are three levels at which organisations operate:

Peak Performance means doing what you do better, faster, and more efficiently within the current paradigm. Real. Valuable. But it has a ceiling — the ceiling of the paradigm itself.

Occasional Breakthrough means transcending the ceiling once, in a moment of inspired disruption. Then returning to the same paradigm with a bigger achievement as the new reference point.

Sustained Greatness means paradigm-busting is expected, distributed, and belongs to every person in the organisation. Raising the bar is not the exceptional act of a visionary leader. It is the organisation's permanent practice. Every standard, once met, becomes the floor of the next standard. Every excellence, once achieved, becomes the baseline from which the next is built.

Jeff Bezos institutionalised this orientation more explicitly than any leader in modern business history. From his very first shareholder letter in 1997 to his last in 2020, every letter began with the same three words: "It's still Day 1." Not as a motivational phrase. As a structural refusal — a refusal to treat any achievement as arrival, to let the organisation settle into the maintenance of what had been built. His warning about the alternative was precise: "Day 2 is stasis. Followed by irrelevance. Followed by excruciating, painful decline."

The paradigm your organisation is most invested in — the one that produced your current success and that everyone defends

instinctively — is the one most worth questioning. Not because it is wrong. Because that is where the next breakthrough lives.

Purpose Outlasts the Leader

There is a distinction that serious leaders must grapple with eventually: the distinction between building a business and building a legacy.

A business generates value during your tenure. A legacy is what you make possible for the leaders who follow — for the people they will serve, and for a world that will be different because the chain of commitment was never broken.

A purpose that can be fulfilled within a single leader's tenure is not a Massive Transformative Purpose. It is a goal. And goals, once achieved, produce the most damaging condition in organisational life — the condition of completion.

Genuine purpose is not complete. It expands. The better you serve it, the more clearly you see how much further it extends. And it must be designed to outlast you.

If your organisation's purpose, standards, and culture depend primarily on your personal presence to be sustained, then you have not built a High-Performance Organisation. You have built a talented team around a strong individual — which is meaningful. But it is not legacy.

Jim Collins and his research team studied 28 companies over 15 years. The defining characteristic of organisations that sustained

greatness across leadership transitions was what Collins called Level 5 leadership — leaders who combined fierce professional will with personal humility, and who built organisations designed to endure beyond their own tenure. The leaders of mediocre companies were frequently defined by the opposite: an identity so wrapped up in the organisation's performance during their time that building something beyond themselves felt like a diminishment rather than a legacy.

Legacy is built when the next generation of leaders carries the purpose forward without needing you there to remind them of it — when the standards you established are held not because you enforced them but because the organisation understands why they matter.

That is the deepest aspiration behind all of this. Not just that you build a High-Performance Organisation in your tenure. But that what you build outlives you — and continues building long after you are gone.

You Began with One Question. You End with a Better One.

You began with a confrontation. A direct question that most leaders find more uncomfortable than they expected: *Are you building a High-Performance Organisation, or a BUSY one?*

Having reflected, owned, asserted, and committed to running, you are now equipped to ask something far more powerful. A question that assumes you have done the work. A question that looks forward rather than backward. A question that has no ceiling.

That question is not in these pages. It is in you. It lives in the specific combination of purpose, people, and potential that your organisation, and only your organisation, contains. No framework can answer it. No model can prescribe it. It can only be discovered through the practice of running at High Performance — day by day, without looking back.

The ROAR Model, Complete

You have made the full journey.

R, Reflect. You confronted what you had built — honestly, without defence. You saw the purpose gap, the strategy gap, the competency compromise. You counted your follow-ups. You named the standards you had let slide. You looked in the mirror and did not look away.

O, Own. You saw the reality of your organisation clearly and without excuses. You identified what your BUSYness was hiding. You understood the two cultures — BUSY and High Performance — and saw honestly which one you have been living in.

A, Assert. You set non-negotiable standards in yourself first, then in every level of the organisation. You chose to create new realities rather than manage existing ones. You demanded what you were willing to model. You named the four non-negotiables and committed to living them.

R, Run. You built the blueprint and committed to the practice. The 90-day plan is yours. The personal shifts are defined. The champions will be named. The standard is alive.

Now: ROAR.

Now. Always. Without stopping.

Exercises — Chapter 10: Sustaining Greatness

The final exercises are not about reflection alone. They are about building the architecture of permanence — the structures, habits, and orientations that ensure High-Performance continues beyond this moment, this year, this leader.

Exercise 1: Seed or Reference Point

— What achievement is your organisation most at risk of treating as a reference point rather than a seed? Name it specifically.

— What would it look like to plant it — to use it this week as the foundation for the next level rather than the conclusion of this one?

— What question would a leader who sees it as a seed ask in the next leadership meeting that a leader treating it as a reference point would never ask?

Exercise 2: Metabolising the Breakdown

— Name the last significant breakdown in your organisation.

— Did you fix it, or metabolise it? What is the honest answer?

— What does that breakdown *reveal* about a structural truth in your organisation that fixing the immediate problem leaves untouched?

— What new understanding does it make available — if you are willing to look?

Exercise 3: Questioning the Paradigm

— Name the paradigm your organisation is most invested in. The one everyone defends instinctively because it is connected to your historical success.

— What would your organisation look like if it broke that paradigm? Describe it specifically.

— What is the first question you would need to ask to begin testing whether that paradigm is still serving the mission — or limiting it?

Exercise 4: Purpose Beyond Your Tenure

— What contribution are you making to something that will outlast you? Be honest.

— If you left your organisation tomorrow, would the purpose survive? The standards? The culture? For how long?

— Who is the next generation of leader who will carry this forward? Are you investing in their development deliberately and structurally — or hoping they will figure it out?

— What one structural change would make this organisation more capable of sustaining its purpose beyond your personal tenure?

The Final Mirror Question

Standing where you are right now, having read this far, having reflected, having looked honestly at the organisation you have built and the leader you have been — what is the very first step that this moment is pointing to?

Not what you need to fix. Not what you need to improve. What is the new horizon? What is the next level of achievement that this organisation, with everything you now know, is capable of becoming?

Write it. Not for anyone else. For yourself. As the first act of creating the next reality.

The Final Commitment

Excellence is the only game worth playing. Purpose is the only reason worth having. And the organisation built with will, held with persistence, and grown with care — that is the only legacy worth leaving.

I commit to building it:

What I will build: _____

Who it will serve: _____

What it will make possible that does not yet exist: _____

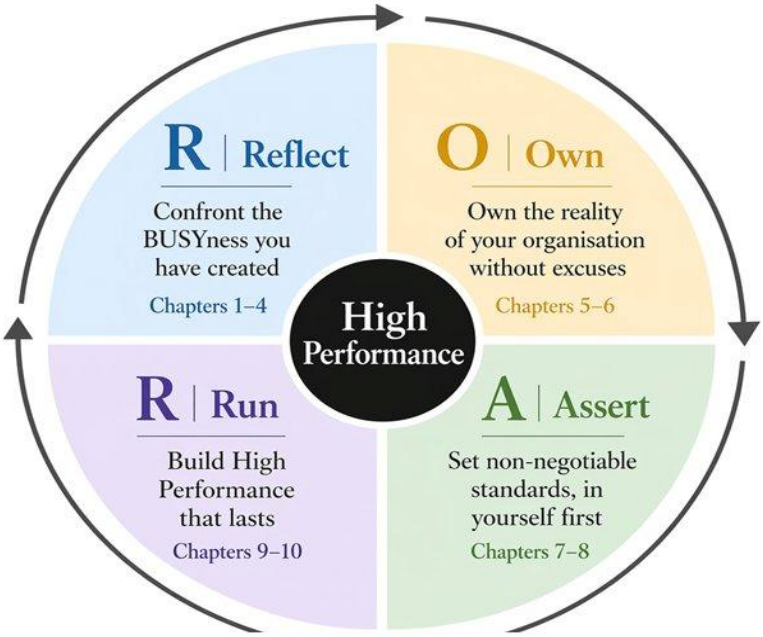
The standard I will hold — every day, without graduation: _____

These are not the final pages. This is the start of what these pages make possible.

Go build it.

A Final Note

The Full Journey in One View



KILL BUSYness.
Begin High Performance.

We began with a mirror. We end with a horizon.

The mirror showed you the organisation as it actually is — not as it is presented in the strategy deck or described in the annual report, but as it is experienced by the people who work in it every day, by

the clients who depend on it, by the market that is constantly, quietly forming an opinion about it.

What that mirror revealed was BUSYness. Not as a character flaw. Not as a failure. But as a human, entirely understandable response to the pressures of building something in a complex, fast-moving world. Organisations become BUSY because the leaders who build them are human — subject to urgency, to the comfort of motion, to the quiet relief of forward momentum even when the direction is not quite right.

And what these pages have tried to do — through every chapter, every framework, every exercise — is create the conditions in which a leader can see that clearly. And then do something about it.

The ROAR model is not a methodology. It is an orientation. Reflect before you act. Own what you have built before you try to change it. Assert standards in yourself before you demand them from others. Run — relentlessly, without looking back — toward the extraordinary.

Reflect, because the truth, seen clearly, is not the enemy. It is the beginning.

Own, because excuses protect the present at the cost of the future. The leader who owns reality completely is the only leader who can change it.

Assert, because standards held firmly are the most powerful cultural force available. The leader who models what they demand creates something that outlasts any initiative.

Run, because High-Performance is not achieved in a moment of insight. It is practised. Every day. Without graduation. Without arrival. With the permanent orientation of someone who understands that excellence is a direction, not a destination.

These pages end. The work does not.

Read honestly. Reflect deeply. Build seriously.

ROAR.

CEO Implementation Toolkit

The following tools are designed to be used alongside the book — during your first read, during your leadership team sessions, and in the 90-day implementation process. Each tool maps directly to a chapter or phase of the ROAR journey.

Tool 1: The BUSYness Audit

How to use: Complete this audit honestly, alone, before sharing it with anyone. Score each item 1–5 (1 = never true, 5 = always true in our organisation).

#	Statement	Your Score (1–5)
1	Our meetings consistently end with specific decisions and named owners	
2	Commitments made in this organisation are honoured without follow-up	
3	Our standards are held firmly, even under pressure	
4	People come to this organisation to fulfil a purpose, not just do a job	
5	Our strategy is visible in the daily decisions we make	
6	Cross-functional collaboration is genuine, not politically managed	

#	Statement	Your Score (1–5)
7	Leaders at every level develop their people deliberately	
8	When problems arise, we address root causes, not just symptoms	
9	The CEO personally models every standard they demand of others	
10	Our culture would survive the departure of the current CEO	

Scoring:

— **40–50:** High-Performance culture. Your work is to sustain and deepen it.

— **28–39:** BUSY-to-High-Performance transition in progress. Prioritise the lowest-scoring items.

— **15–27:** BUSY culture. The ROAR framework is your roadmap. Begin with personal change.

— **Below 15:** Urgent intervention required. Begin with Chapter 8: The CEO's personal non-negotiables.

Tool 2: The Follow-Up Dependency Index (FDI)

How to use: Track every follow-up message you send and receive across one full working week.

Day	Follow-ups I sent	Follow-ups I received
Monday		
Tuesday		

Day	Follow-ups I sent	Follow-ups I received
Wednesday		
Thursday		
Friday		
Week Total		

Your FDI: Total follow-ups ÷ Total commitments made this week = _____

— **FDI below 0.1:** NFR culture is operating. Protect and model it.

— **FDI 0.1–0.4:** Transitioning. Identify the top 3 sources of follow-up dependency.

— **FDI above 0.4:** BUSY culture. Begin NFR culture installation immediately (see Chapter 6).

The three questions your FDI is answering:

5. Are commitments being made clearly?
6. Are commitments being owned fully?
7. Is the culture tolerating non-ownership?

Tool 3: Leadership Meeting Redesign

Current state (most organisations): Meetings are status updates. People report. Leaders listen or react. Nothing is decided. Everyone leaves without clarity on who owns what.

The High-Performance meeting standard — applied immediately:

Before every meeting, the convener must define:

— **Purpose:** What specific decision or outcome does this meeting produce?

— **Participants:** Only people who are necessary for that decision (target: under 8)

— **Preparation:** What must each person have read or prepared before arriving?

During the meeting:

— No open-ended discussion without a decision attached to it

— Every action captured in real time: what, who, by when

— The last 5 minutes: read back every commitment. Every person confirms theirs.

After the meeting:

— One summary message: decisions made, commitments owned, next review date

— **No follow-up messages.** If a commitment is not honoured, the conversation is direct and immediate — not managed through reminders.

This week: Apply this standard to the next three meetings you convene. Measure the difference in outcomes and time.

Tool 4: Competency Chain Audit

How to use: For each link in your organisation's competency chain, answer the diagnostic question honestly. Circle Y (Yes) or N (No).

Link	Diagnostic Question	Y / N
1. Recruitment	Is every hire made against a clear competency framework, with structured interviews and a real assessment process?	
2. Training	Does every new person receive structured, certified onboarding — not just informal learning on the job?	
3. Promotion	Is every manager and supervisor specifically prepared for leadership before being given leadership responsibility?	
4. Sales	Is every client your organisation serves the right client — right fit, right margin, right expectation?	
5. Delivery	Does what your organisation delivers match or exceed what it promises, every time?	
6. Brand	Is the experience your clients have of you worthy of the brand you believe you have?	
7. Future	Is your organisation building the capabilities today that it will need to win in 3–5 years?	

Count your N answers: Each N is a broken link. The first N in your chain is the one to address first — because every link downstream inherits its compromise.

Tool 5: The 90-Day Personal Commitment Template

Complete this before beginning Week 2 of the blueprint. This is your personal covenant — not with the organisation, but with yourself.

My honest assessment of the BUSYness I have created:

_____

_____

The three personal behaviours I will change, beginning this week:

8. I will stop:

   _____

   _

9. I will start:

   _____

   _

10. I will hold:

    _____

    _

The one person who will hold me accountable to these changes:

Name: _____ How we will meet: _____ Frequency: _____

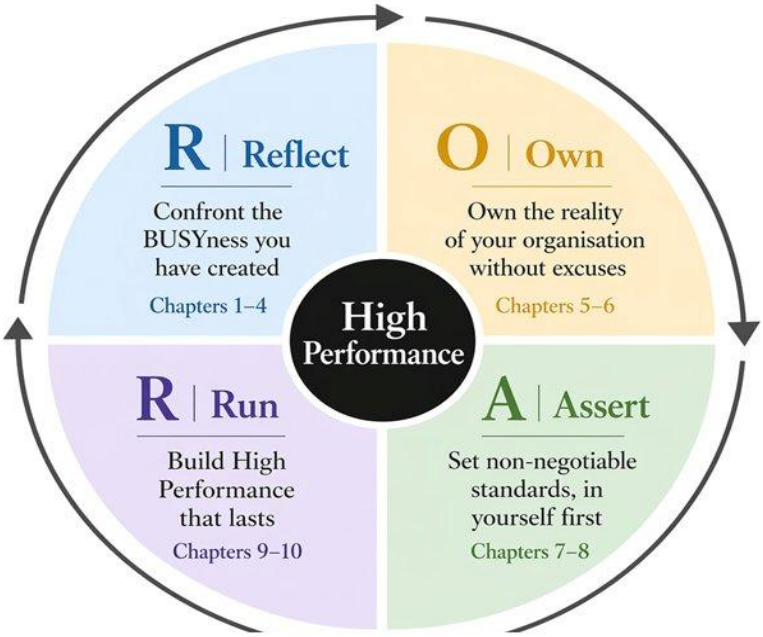
My 90-day commitment:

I commit to the full ROAR journey — not as a reading exercise, not as a team programme, but as a personal transformation that begins in my behaviour, my calendar, my meetings, and my standards. I acknowledge that the organisation I lead has been shaped by the leader I have been. And I commit to building the organisation I am now capable of creating.

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Return to this page at the end of Week 4, Month 2, and Month 3. What has changed? What must change further?

About the Framework



KILL BUSYness.
Begin High Performance.

The ROAR Model is the organising spine of this work and of the transformation it describes:

Phase	Chapters	Focus
R, Reflect	Chapters 1–4	Confront the BUSYness you have created

Phase	Chapters	Focus
O, Own	Chapters 5–6	Own the reality of your organisation without excuses
A, Assert	Chapters 7–8	Set non-negotiable standards in yourself first
R, Run	Chapters 9–10	Build High-Performance that lasts

The Four Non-Negotiables

11. No Follow-Up Required (NFR) — a commitment made is a commitment honoured
12. World-Class Best Practices — in every function, continuously upgraded
13. Break the Silo — departmentalism is a cancer; collaboration is the standard
14. People as Source, Not Resource — partner, develop, invest, respect

The Five Dimensions of High Performance

15. Purpose Architecture — purpose as a filter, not a statement
16. Strategy Execution — Where to Play and How to Win, alive in daily decisions
17. Competency Investment — closing the competency gap continuously
18. Culture Installation — what is modelled, recognised, addressed, and refused

19. Ecosystem Building — partnerships that create genuine, mutual, long-term value

The Master Diagnostic

Does this organisation depend on follow-up and reminders to get things done?

If yes, you are in a BUSY culture. And now you know how to change it.

"Culture is not what is written on the wall. It is what happens when nobody is watching. And in a High-Performance culture, nobody needs to watch. Because the standard is alive in every person, in every space, in every commitment made and honoured without reminder."

Acknowledgements

About the Author

Manoj Onkar is the founder of Management Innovations, an organisation development consultancy with a singular mission: Reinventing Management and Helping Leaders build Extraordinary Organisations. Over 25 years, he and his team have worked across India, Thailand, the Philippines, and the United Kingdom, helping organisations move from intention to genuine, sustained change.

He has trained more than 100,000 people across 30 industries, and has personally developed more than 1,000 trainers and coaches. His clients have included Reliance Group, Tata Steel, TCS, Accenture, Zydus Group, Kirloskar, ONGC, Kotak Foundation, GMDC, Pay Nearby, and many others. He was privileged to have delivered customised leadership programmes for the Chief Minister of Gujarat, Shri Narendra Modi (now Prime Minister of India), along with his team of ministers and IAS Officers. His work has also extended to public institutions including the Lokayukta of Karnataka, police organisations, hospitals, and educational institutions.

Earlier in his career, Manoj served as Master Trainer, Coach, and Head of Training Delivery and International Partnerships at NIS Sparta (Reliance Group) — at one time Asia's largest corporate training organisation. He was National and Global Faculty with

Landmark Education (now Landmark Worldwide), the world's largest personal transformation organisation. He was also Founder Consultant for DPS Bopal (Kalorex Group) and Zydus School for Excellence (Zydus Group).

His work is grounded in globally recognised methodologies, including Theory U by Dr Otto Scharmer of MIT, the Balanced Scorecard for strategy execution, and Exponential Organisation design. The ROAR model at the heart of this work — Reflect, Own, Assert, Run — is the distillation of more than two decades of working with leaders across industries and cultures to close the gap between the organisation they intended to build and the one they actually have.

One of his client organisations, a 60-year-old Thailand-based company, was awarded by their Prime Minister as the Best Managed Small and Medium Enterprise following a two-year holistic organisation development intervention led by Manoj and his team. They continue to be recognised nationally.

His current focus is on creating long-term, sustainable organisations through Leadership Transformation, Culture Transformation, and Systems Transformation — and on creating social impact through awareness-based collective action.

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"BUSYness is not a time management problem.

It is not a people problem.

It is a LEADERSHIP problem."

Your organisation is full of hardworking, committed people. Everyone is busy. And yet the results are not what they should be. Problems keep recurring. Good people are quietly disengaging. The strategy exists in a document but not in daily decisions.

The name for it is **BUSYness.** And this book is its cure.

M A N O J O N K A R

Founder, Management Innovations · www.managementinnovations.co.in

Adhyan Books

ISBN 978-XX-XXXX-XXX-X | ₹[price] India | $[price] International